Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

♠ K Q J 9 6 5
♥ A K
♦ 8 7 5
♣ A 5

♠ 7
♥ J 7 6
♦ K 9 6 3 2
♣ 7 6 4 3

♠ 2
♥ 9 5 3 2
♦ A Q J 10 4
♣ Q 9 8

♠ A 10 8 4 3
♥ Q 10 8 4
♦ —
♣ K J 10 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♠	Pass	4♦
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♦
Pass	7♠		
All Pass			

7♠ by North
Lead: ♥3

Partner's 4♦ bid is a Splinter Bid. It shows opening hand strength, at least 4-card ♠ support, and a singleton or void in ♦s.

Normally you would not ask for Key-Cards with this ♦ holding. But since you know partner has at most a singleton, and that it is not the singleton ♦A, you are safe to do so. You say 4NT, partner replies 6♦. What next?

WOW! Partner has one Key-Card and a ♦ void. So the Key-Card is the ♠A. You don't know what the rest of partner's hand is, but he can surely take care of that small ♣. You bid 7♠.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ 4 ♦ A K 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q	
♠ 10 4 3 ♥ K Q 8 7 2 ♦ J ♣ 9 7 6 5	N W E S	♠ J 9 6 2 ♥ J 9 5 3 ♦ 5 2 ♣ 4 3 2
	♠ K 8 7 ♥ A 10 6 ♦ Q 9 7 4 ♣ J 10 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]
Pass	5♥	Pass	5♠
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

7NT by South
Lead: ♥K

Your 2NT response shows 8+ points, with no 5-card biddable suit.

You support the ♦s and partner bids 4NT. What is your next bid?

With ♦s as trump you have 1 Key-Card, the ♥A. You answer 5♣ and partner bids 5♥. What is your bid?

This is the Queen Ask, wanting to know if you hold the ♦Q. Since you do have it you should bid a suit in which you hold a King. So you bid 5♠. That spurred partner on - he was fishing for 7♦ but when you told him you had the ♦Q, ♥A and ♠K he was able to bid 7NT.

Board 3
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ — ♥ K Q 10 8 6 3 2 ♦ 5 3 ♣ J 10 8 2	
♠ A K J 6 5 2 ♥ 5 ♦ A 8 7 4 ♣ 7 5		♠ 10 9 7 4 3 ♥ 4 ♦ 10 9 6 2 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ Q 8 ♥ A J 9 7 ♦ K Q J ♣ A K Q 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by North
Lead: ♦10

Partner's 2♥ is a positive response, 8+ points with a 5+ card suit.

Even though it is tempting, bidding RKCB now would be a mistake because of your doubleton ♠ loser. Instead just support the ♥s. Partner cannot pass, you both know you are forced to game. In fact, partner bids 3♠.

Partner promises first round ♠ control so NOW you can bid RCKB. When you bid 4NT partner answers 6♥. This shows 1 Key-Card and a void in a suit higher than ♥s. Knowing you are missing either the ♦A or ♥K you pass.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K 10 7 2 ♥ A K 8 6 5 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 6 4	
♠ 6 ♥ Q 4 3 ♦ Q J 7 5 2 ♣ Q J 8 3	N W E S	♠ 9 ♥ J 10 9 2 ♦ 10 9 6 ♣ 10 9 7 5 2
	♠ A Q J 8 5 4 3 ♥ 7 ♦ A K 4 ♣ A K	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♦	Pass	7NT
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen
3. asks for kings

7NT by South
Lead: ♦5

Your 2♥ response shows 8+ points, with at least 5 ♥s.

Your hand is looking better and better. You already gave a positive response so you know you are forced to game. It is better to keep the bidding low to allow more investigating room so you bid 3♠. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

With ♠s agreed as trumps you have two Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♥A. With no trump Queen you respond 5♥. Partner now says 5NT. What do you reply?

Partner is asking for Kings and you have just 1, the ♥K. Remember, the ♠K is not a King, it is a Key-Card which you have already counted. So you bid 6♦. Partner counts 13 tricks and bids 7NT.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A K 9 6 5 4 ♥ K Q 6 ♦ K Q J 2 ♣ —	
♠ 8 2 ♥ J 9 4 2 ♦ A 7 ♣ 9 8 4 3 2		♠ 10 ♥ 10 7 5 3 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ A Q 10 7 6
	♠ Q J 7 3 ♥ A 8 ♦ 10 8 6 4 ♣ K J 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♣	Pass	4♥
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦3

Partner's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points and good ♠ support.

What you DO NOT say next is 4NT. If partner answered 1 Key-Card you would not know what to do. If he has a red Ace you can make slam, but if his one Key-Card were the ♣A you couldn't. Instead you make a control-showing bid of 4♣, promising first round control. Partner obliges you by bidding 4♥. What is your next bid?

Partner's bidding is like the Sherlock Holmes tale Silver Blaze, about the dog that didn't bark. Partner's ♥ bid shows that he **DOES** have the ♥A, but equally important it shows that he **DOES NOT** have the ♦A. So you know you don't have a ♥ loser but do have a ♦ loser. You bid 6♠.